After a home fire

If you've been through a house fire, all kinds of emotions and thoughts will probably be coming up for you. Learn what to do and where to get help as you recover, so you can get back to 'normal' life when it's safe to do so.

Summary

- It's not always safe to go home straight away after a fire. You might need to stay somewhere else for a while.
- Contact your insurance company as soon as possible to get their advice.
- Don't remove anything damaged by fire from your home before speaking to your insurance company.
- You'll need to make sure your home is secured, and essential services turned off until you return.
- Recovery takes time. Get help from professionals if you need it.

Can I stay in my home?

Only if it's safe

It's normal to want to be in your own home and going through your belongings after a house fire, but it's not always safe to be there. Damage from fire can make it unsafe, especially if the structure of your home has been weakened.

The Fire Officer in Charge decides whether it's safe to stay or not. They might call the local council building inspector to assess the safety of the building.

If you can’t stay in your home

Organise somewhere to stay

Check with your insurance company if they will cover the cost of emergency accommodation. If you don't have this option, try to stay with friends or family until it's safe to return home.

Take personal items with you

If you can't stay in your home, you might be able to collect some important belongings before leaving to stay somewhere else. Check with the Fire Officer in Charge if it's safe for you to go inside. If it is, here is a suggested list of things to collect:

- ID cards, like your driver’s license, Medicare card, passport
- Car and house keys
- Mobile phone and charger
- Laptop and charger
- Insurance contact details and policy
- Wallet, credit cards and/or cheque books
- Medication and prescriptions
    - Note: any medication that's been close to heat and smoke should be thrown out and replaced.
- Mobility aids, glasses, hearing aids
- Valuables like jewellery, photographs, cash etc

- Legal documents.

Other things to do

- Contact your gas, electricity, water and internet provider to cancel services until you move back in.
- Cancel any delivery services.
- Re-direct your mail.
- Change your address with important contacts like your employer, schools, insurance company and neighbours.
- Let your local police station know that your property has been involved in a fire and that no one is living there for a while.

Speak to your insurance company

If you have home or contents insurance, you should call your insurance company as soon as possible after the fire.

Speak to your insurance company about:

- what happened
- what has been damaged/destroyed
- what information they need from you
- what you should do now
- how to protect your property from more damage
    - including covering holes where rain could get in, and securing the property so people can't break in and steal or damage your belongings
- any cleaning or repair services you need
- whether your policy covers emergency accommodation.

Once it's safe to be in your home again, make sure you don't throw out any damaged belongings without speaking to your insurance company first. Keep any receipts for emergency security or repair work you have done, and start making a list of damaged items and take photographs of each item if you can.

Refer to your insurance policy and speak to your insurance company for more advice. If you can't remember the name of your insurance company or the details are not available, you can find out by submitting an enquiry to the Insurance Council of Australia or calling them on 1300 728 228.

Securing your property

If you own your home

You're responsible for ensuring your home is safe from more damage due to weather or people breaking in to steal or vandalise your property. Your insurance company may not cover any damage after the fire has happened.

Speak to your insurance company for advice on what to do to secure your house and if they can help. You might need to organise temporary fencing, roofing or shutters to protect your house.

If you're renting

If you rent your home, you need to contact the property manager and ask them to secure your home after the fire.

Re-connecting gas, electricity, water and internet

Your gas, electricity, water supply, internet and phone lines might have been damaged, destroyed or disconnected due to the fire. If you own your home, it's your responsibility to have the services:

- inspected
- repaired
- re-connected

If you're renting, speak to your property manager to have your services inspected, repaired and re-connected.

Cleaning up after the fire

Smoke, soot and firefighting water can damage your house, furniture and belongings. Walls, carpet, furniture, curtains, clothing and other belongings are all likely to be affected. The good news is, you might be able to save some of your belongings, even if they have been affected by heat, smoke or water.

If you have insurance, see if your insurance company will organise professional cleaners to deep clean your property and help remove damaged items and materials.

Cleaning tips

- Open windows and use a fan to get the air moving. This helps with getting rid of the smell and moisture.
- Dry everything that's wet as soon as possible.
- Take curtains, bedding and large items you can't wash to a dry cleaner.
- Wash clothing in warm water with detergent.
- Wash walls, furniture and floors with detergent. Wear rubber gloves.

Electrical appliances will need to be checked by an electrician or authorised service provider before you use them again.

Asbestos must be removed

If your home contains asbestos, you or your rental provider need to organise a licensed asbestos removalist before you can return home. Speak to your insurance company, the local council or property manager to organise this.

Where to get help with recovery

Your local Council Municipal Recovery Manager	**For advice on local community support services.**	
Consumer Affairs Victoria	If renting you may be entitled to end your tenancy or to reduced rent.	1300 558 181
VicEmergency Hotline	Check current local incidents, fire danger ratings, and planned fuel reduction burns.	1800 226 226
Housing Call Centre	For public housing renters.	13 11 72 (24 hour service)
Centrelink	For Exceptional Circumstances Relief Help.	13 28 50

RSPCA	For information regarding pets and animals.	(03) 9224 2222

Coping with a stressful event



It's normal to have strong reactions after a stressful event like a fire. Each person's experience after something like a fire is different, but there are a few common responses you might be feeling:

- shock
- disbelief
- anger
- fear
- loss
- despair
- hopelessness

Know that whatever feelings you experience are normal reactions to an abnormal event.

Looking after yourself

Take the time to acknowledge what you have been through and give yourself permission to adjust. Here are some tips for recovering well after a fire.

Prioritise rest and looking after yourself

Eat regular, nutritious food, and move your body.

Have a routine

Return to your regular routine and keep structure in your day to care for yourself at this time

Spend time with people

Reach out to your social connections and spend time with others.

Don't use drugs and alcohol

Find healthier ways to cope with the stress.

Reach out for professional support

Talking about feelings can help with the recovery process, reach out for professional support. Your GP is a great place to start.

Take it easy

You're more likely to experience illness and injury after a stressful event like this, so be kind to yourself.

Avoid making major life decisions

This isn't the time for big changes and big decisions. Just take each day at a time.

Signs you might need professional help

If you're experiencing any of the following, we recommend getting professional help as you recover from what has happened:

- feeling very distressed, frightened, irritable or jumpy a lot of the time
- unable to carry out your normal roles at work, school and/or with your family
- feeling sad, overwhelmed or experiencing feelings of hopelessness, or
- thinking of harming yourself or someone else.

Help can come from your doctor, a psychologist, counsellor or Lifeline (13 11 14).

Where to get mental health and wellbeing support

Organisation	Services	Contact
Your Doctor or General Practitioner (GP)	Can refer you to other services, and prescribe medication.	
Lifeline	For 24 hour counselling and emotional support service and referral.	13 11 14
Victorian Emergency Recovery service	Mental Health and Wellbeing support	1300 799 232

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